

SACHITA NISHAL

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EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Technology and Social Behavior (TSB) 2020 - 2026
Joint PhD Program in Computer Science and Communication Studies
Northwestern University (NU), Evanston, IL
Advisor: Dr. Nicholas Diakopoulos

Bachelor of Engineering, Computer Science 2016 - 2020
Birla Institute of Technology and Science (BITS) Pilani, Goa, India
Thesis Advisor: Dr. Luís Amaral

WORK EXPERIENCE

Microsoft Research, New York (FATE) 2024
Summer Research Intern
Mentor: Dr. Jenn Wortman Vaughan

Microsoft Research, India 2020
Summer Research Intern
Mentor: Dr. Joyojeet Pal

Amaral Lab, Northwestern University 2019
Research Intern
Mentor: Dr. Luís Amaral

HONORS AND AWARDS

DIS 2025 Best Paper Honorable Mention 2025
Nominated as a student attendee for HCIC 2025 by Northwestern University 2025
Selected as a mentee for CSST Summer Institute 2025 2025
ACM SIGCHI Gary Marsden Travel Award 2025
David Zarefsky Graduate Fellowship @ Northwestern U. School of Communication 2024-2025
The Graduate School Conference Travel Grant @ Northwestern U. 2025
Undergraduate Summer Research Award @ BITS Pilani 2018

ARCHIVAL PUBLICATIONS

Values as Problems, Principles, and Tensions in Sociotechnical System Design for Journalism
S. Nishal and N. Diakopoulos
Proceedings of the ACM Conference on *Designing Interactive Systems Conference (DIS)*, 2025
Best Paper Honorable Mention

News Futures: (Re-)Designing Sociotechnical Systems for News Production and Consumption
S. Nishal, M. Aubin Le Quéré, B. McInnis, B. Jones, K. Vaccaro, T. Aitamurto, M. Naaman, N. Diakopoulos
Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA), 2025
Co-lead workshop organizer at CHI 2025

Understanding Practices around Computational News Discovery Tools in the Domain of Science Journalism
S. Nishal, J. Sinchai, N. Diakopoulos
Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction (CSCW), 2024

From Crowd Ratings to Predictive Models of Newsworthiness to Support Science Journalism

S. Nishal, N. Diakopoulos

Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction (CSCW), 2022

Voting with the Stars: Analyzing Partisan Engagement between Celebrities and Politicians in India

R. Mothilal, D. Mishra, S. Nishal, F. Lalani, J. Pal

Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction (CSCW), 2022

DISMISS: Database of Indian Social Media Influencers (Snowballed Sequentially) on Twitter

A. Arya, S. De, D. Mishra, G. Shekhawat, A. Sharma, A. Panda, F. Lalani, P. Singh, R. Mothilal, R. Grover, S. Nishal, S. Dash, S. Rashid, S. Akbar, J. Pal

Proceedings of the International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media (ICWSM), 2022

Devotees on an Astroturf: Media, Politics, and Outrage in the Suicide of a Popular FilmStar

S.Z. Akbar, A. Sharma, D. Mishra, R.K. Mothilal, H. Negi, S. Nishal, A. Panda, J. Pal

Proceedings of the 5th ACM SIGCAS/SIGCHI Conference on Computing and Sustainable Societies (COMPASS), 2022

UNDER REVIEW

Caged Birds and Cute Bookworms: Implicit Gender Bias in Narratives by Large Language Models

S. Nishal and J. Bandy Under Review at *ACL Rolling Review*

INVITED TALKS

Generative AI in the Newsroom: Design and Evaluation

Designing for Agency in LLM-Infused Writing Support Tools for Science Journalism 2025
Workshop on Tools for Thought at ACM CHI Conference, Yokohama.

Evaluating Generative AI Tools in Your Newsroom. 2024
Computation+Journalism Symposium 2024, Boston (with C. Li and N. Diakopoulos)

Blueprints for Evaluating Generative AI in Journalism. 2024
Aspen Digital's AI & News Event 2024, New York City.

Building and Evaluating Trustworthy Tools with Generative AI. 2023
SRCCON 2023, Minneapolis (with E. Ulken)

Imagining Future(s) of AI-Driven Storytelling. 2023
Story Discovery At Scale 2023, Palo Alto.

Generative AI in the Newsroom: Literacy and Policy

How Can Journalists Report Using AI? 2025
Journalism and Women Symposium (JAWS) event 2025, Chicago (with M. Cai)

How Can Journalists Understand and Report On AI? 2023
JAWS 2023, Chicago (with M. Cai)

Creativity and Bias with Generative AI

Cute Bookworms and Caged Birds: Implicit Biases Toward Female Characters in LLM Stories. 2025
CoDeX Symposium 2025, Chicago.

Who Gets to Be a Jerk with a Heart of Gold: Implicit Gender Biases in LLM-Generated Narratives. 2024
Story Discovery At Scale 2024, Palo Alto.

WORKSHOPS AND POSTERS (LIGHTLY PEER-REVIEWED)

Designing for Agency in LLM-Infused Writing Support Tools for Science Journalism

S. Nishal, M. Lee, N. Diakopoulos, J. W. Vaughan

Workshop on Tools for Thought at ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, 2025.

“Good enough” news? Generative AI’s Impacts on Local News Reporting

N. Hagar and S. Nishal

Pre-conference on AI in Journalism From a Global Perspective at ICA Annual Conference, 2025.

De-jargonizing Science for Journalists with GPT-4: A Pilot Study

S. Nishal, E. Lee, N. Diakopoulos

Computation + Journalism Symposium, 2024.

Domain-Specific Evaluation Strategies for AI in Journalism

S. Nishal, C. Li, N. Diakopoulos

Workshop on Evaluating AI at ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, 2024.

Envisioning the Applications and Implications of Generative AI in the Newsroom

S. Nishal, N. Diakopoulos

Workshop on Generative AI and HCI at ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, 2023.

Motivations, Goals, and Pathways for AI Literacy for Journalism

S. Nishal, M. Cai

Workshop on AI Literacy at ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, 2023.

Designing Interactive, Configurable and Transparent Algorithmic Systems to Support Journalistic Decision-Making

S. Nishal

Doctoral Consortium at ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency (FAccT), 2023.

Measuring the Impact of Trope-based Novelty on Cinematic Success

S. Nishal, L. A. N. Amaral

International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), 2022.

AI-Driven News Recommender Systems for Science Journalists

S. Nishal, N. Diakopoulos

Computation+Journalism Symposium (C+J), 2022.

RESEARCH MENTORSHIP

Eric Lee, Undergraduate student at Northwestern University 2024

Jasmine Wu, Undergraduate student at Northwestern University 2022

SERVICE

Program Committee Member for DIS Provocations and Works-in-Progress (2025), FAccT (2024)

Peer Reviewer for CSCW (2022, 2023*, 2024, 2025*), CHI (2023, 2024*, 2025), DIS (2023*, 2024, 2025*), Digital Journalism (2025), Journalism Studies (2024), NAACL Queer in AI Workshop (2024, 2025), UIST (2023*, 2025), AAAI’s AI Magazine (2023), NordiCHI (2022),

* indicates special recognition for peer review

Co-organizer for PhD Book Club, run with support from HCI+D Center at NU (2022-2025)

Student Mentor for Incoming PhD Students in TSB (2021-Present)

Ad-hoc Organizing for pre-conference practice talks with PhD students in TSB (2022-Present)

TEACHING

How LLMs Mimic Human Language, Computing Everywhere**, Northwestern University 2025

Designed and co-taught with Maryam Hedayati (~15 students).

Learning Python with EarSketch , Computing Everywhere**, Northwestern University Designed and co-taught with Maryam Hedayati (15-35 students).	2022-2024
Digital Propaganda and Repression , COMM-ST 395, Northwestern University Teaching assistant (~15 students).	2024
Compiler Construction , CS F363, BITS Pilani Teaching assistant (~200 students).	2020
Environment, Development and Climate Change , GS F212, BITS Pilani Teaching assistant (~30 students).	2018

*** Computing Everywhere is a hands-on workshop for increasing computational literacy among Northwestern undergrads, with a competitive application process for instructors.*